

KOH SAMUI

THE AREA GUIDE

Where to stay, what you'll love, and what nobody tells you



Seven areas · Honest pros and cons · 250+ places I actually go
@ai.yu0278

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Every area on Koh Samui is somebody's perfect holiday and somebody else's mistake. The island is small — 50 km around — but the difference between the east coast and the west coast in January is the difference between red flags on the beach and a flat mirror at sunset.

So this guide isn't a list of highlights. For each of the seven areas you get four things: what it actually is, why people choose it, what tends to disappoint them, and who shouldn't book it. Then the full list of spots — attractions, hotels, restaurants, shopping, beach clubs — so you can plan the days without opening ten more tabs.

TWO THINGS WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU CHOOSE

Season matters more than area. Roughly December to March, the east coast (Chaweng, Lamai) takes the swell: high waves, and at Chaweng, rip currents. From around May to October the east is calm and the west coast (Nathon, Lipa Noi, Taling Ngam) has the long low tides — beautiful for sunsets, less so for swimming at 4pm.

Transport decides your radius. If you won't ride a scooter or rent a car, stay in Chaweng, Lamai or Bophut. Everywhere else on this list assumes wheels.



THE SEVEN AREAS

1. **CHAWENG** — *The main strip*
2. **LAMAI** — *Chaweng's calmer sister*
3. **BOPHUT & BANGRAK** — *Fisherman's Village and the north-east corner*
4. **MAENAM** — *The quiet long beach*
5. **NATHON** — *The island's real town*
6. **LIPA NOI** — *The sunset beach*
7. **TALING NGAM** — *The south-west, and the Five Islands*

CHAWENG

The main strip

Chaweng is the beach everyone means when they say "Koh Samui". Six kilometres of wide white sand on the east coast, with a road behind it that never really switches off — malls, massage shops, night market, bars. It's 15 minutes from the airport and it's where I send anyone who wants their first Samui trip to be easy: you can land, drop your bag, and walk to dinner without renting anything.



WHY PEOPLE CHOOSE IT

- The widest, whitest sand on the island — and the best swimming water from May to October.
- Everything within walking distance: pharmacies, Central Samui mall, night market, beach clubs, dozens of cafés.
- The only area with real nightlife — beach clubs, live music, ARK Bar's or Elephant Beach Club fire show.
- Closest to the airport (10–15 min), so you don't lose an hour arriving.
- Widest hotel range on the island, from 900 THB guesthouses to luxury Garrya Tongsai Bay.

WHAT MIGHT DISAPPOINT YOU

- In winter season (roughly December to March) the east coast gets high waves and rip currents. Red flags go up and some days swimming is genuinely unsafe — this is the single thing most winter visitors are not warned about. If you still prefer staying in Chaweng in winter choose the area between Marine Resort and Casa De Mar, the sea is quiet there in winter (but in summer it has low tide).
- Storm swell eats the sand in front of some hotels, so "beachfront" can mean a sandbag wall in winter.
- The central stretch has jet skis, beach vendors and loud music from around 12pm.
- The main road is noisy, and there's near-constant construction somewhere along it.
- It is the most expensive area for food if you stay on the beach road — and the least Thai-feeling.
- Close to airport — you will always hear planes while staying on Chaweng beach.

NOT THE RIGHT AREA IF

- Anyone whose main goal is quiet. Chaweng Noi (the south cove) is calmer, but central Chaweng is not a peaceful place.
- Families with small children travelling in December–March, when the surf and currents are strongest.
- Travellers looking for "the real Thailand" — this is the tourist heart of the island, and it doesn't pretend otherwise.

CHAWENG

everything worth your time

ATTRACTIONS

- Lad Koh viewpoint
- Chaweng Beach
- Haven Gate
- Chaweng Night Market
- White Market
- Pagoda Khao Hua Jook
- Capybara World
- Cocoon Viewpoint
- Shri Shiva Dham Temple
- Wat Sawang Arom
- Jump Shack
- Kekus Waterfall
- Chaweng Chinese Temple
- Cats Cafe & Co-Working
- Heart Shape & Elephant Care
- Dog and Cat Rescue

HOTELS

- OZO Chaweng Samui
- Amari Resort Samui
- COSI Samui
- Chaweng Garden Beach
- Banana Fan Sea
- Centara Reserve
- Samui City Hotel
- Hyatt Regency
- Pott Guesthouse
- Dara Samui Beach
- The Fair House
- Top Chaweng
- Baan Chaweng
- Vana Belle Luxury Resort
- Garrya Tongsai Bay
- Samui Blue Orchid
- SALA Samui Chaweng
- The Library
- Avani Chaweng
- Baan Poon
- Jalmin Boutique Hotel
- Kirikayan Boutique Resort
- Lub d Koh Samui
- Leva Boutique Hotel

RESTAURANTS & CAFÉS

- Moonrise Seafood & Beachbar
- Babou
- The Roof Samui
- Highland Paradise
- Flo Coffee Roaster
- Como bake & brunch
- Allegro
- Blooming Gallery
- One cake
- A piece of cake
- La Fabrique French Bakery
- JoeJoe's Pies
- Sky Chef Sea View
- Meal Prep Samui
- The bagelsamui
- Healthy Lab Cafe
- Talay Beach Restaurant

SHOPPING

- Central Samui
- Haven Shopping Mall
- Nature Jewelry
- Exotic Eve co.

BEACH CLUBS

- Elephant
- ARK Bar
- Seen Club
- Cabanas
- Sandbox
- LOVE
- Sociatel

